continuing today. The great real estate balloons which were inflated—and then burst so disastrously—during the Roaring Twenties were almost entirely fueled by purely speculative buying and selling.

Despite all the frenzied activity of property trading, there was little genuine desire for ownership on the part of the speculators. In those days, a piece of property could—and often did—change hands dozens of times, but not because anyone anywhere along the line actually wanted to own land, build a home or operate income property. Each momentary "owner" of a piece of property had but a single thought in his mind—to sell as soon as he could and to make as large a profit as possible.

For example, there were an estimated 2000 real estate offices and 25,000 real estate salesmen in Miami, Florida, alone in 1925. Theoretically, they sold property—ranging from single lots to huge tracts of land. In actual practice, all that most of them sold were "binders." The buyer paid a small percentage of the agreed sales price of a property and received a receipt which constituted a binder; the property was then his until the next payment fell due 30 or 60 days later. The overwhelming majority of buyers sold their binders just as soon as they could realize a profit on them.

With prices spiraling wildly, they seldom had to wait more than a few days —or at most, a few weeks—before finding another feverish speculator who would give them more money than they'd paid.

There was more truth than humor in the following tale that made the rounds at the height of the 1920s* Florida land boom. According to the story, a Miami realtor had taken a prospective buyer out to look at a dismal and

utterly useless swamp tract. The client stared at the forbidding landscape in dismay.

"No one could ever build anything on this land!" he said.

"It's worthless!"